

THE DUNGEON LORD'S MONTHLY

Game Design Document

"Largely Factual Since Issue 7"

v0.1 — March 2026

Overview

The Dungeon Lord's Monthly is a dungeon management sim with a Pratchett-esque satirical tone. The primary UI framing device is an in-universe publication ecosystem — players receive information, tips, hero intel, and world news through a series of magazines, tabloids, and catalogs rather than through traditional menus or HUD elements.

The game is built with SwiftGodot. The core fantasy is managing an incompetent but lovable dungeon workforce, defending against increasingly bold hero incursions, and building a dungeon worthy of coverage in The Dungeonist — which is harder than it sounds.

Tone & Influences

The primary tonal touchstone is Terry Pratchett: dry wit, earnest absurdism, and a deep affection for the ridiculous. The world takes itself seriously; only the player is allowed to notice how funny it all is.

Secondary influences:

- Dungeon Keeper — you are the villain, and that's fine
- Dwarf Fortress — losing is fun; emergent stories matter
- Papers, Please — UI-as-world-building
- Theme Hospital — workforce mismanagement as comedy

Publication Ecosystem

All game information is delivered through in-universe publications. The player's "menu" is a reading desk. New publications unlock as the dungeon grows in reputation and wealth.

The Dungeon Lord's Monthly (DLM)

"Largely Factual Since Issue 7"

The core publication. A scrappy tabloid that arrives regularly and forms the backbone of the player's information diet. Unreliable, entertaining, and indispensable. Available from the start of the game.

Recurring columns and sections:

- Crumplethwaite's Advice Column — "Occasionally Wrong, Never Uncertain". Expert dungeon advice from someone who has never successfully run a dungeon. The primary source of deliberately bad tips.
- The Minion Manager — Gerald's column. Workplace grievances disguised as management advice. Gerald is perpetually underemployed, financially stressed, and files eyewitness accounts that contradict themselves halfway through. His column floats between publications depending on which one will pay his freelance fee that month.
- Hero Rumors — "We Asked Around". Advance intel on incoming heroes, sourced from tavern gossip and at least one unreliable informant. Accuracy varies.
- Classifieds — "Probably Helpful". Monster job listings, dungeon supply ads, Gerald looking for work.
- News — "All The News We Could Verify In Time For Print, And Some We Couldn't".

Hero Defeat of the Month

A recurring DLM column highlighting an epically funny hero defeat. Source material comes from the player's own dungeon first (procedurally generated from actual in-game events), then from other players' dungeons once a sufficient player base exists.

Key design principle: the column's tone matches the nature of the defeat rather than following a fixed house style. This makes each issue feel like a different writer filed the piece — which fits DLM's understaffed editorial reality perfectly.

Defeat categories and their tonal signatures:

- Elaborate trap chain (Rube Goldberg style) — breathless and sensational. Exclamation points. "Our reporter was on the scene." The kind of piece DLM puts on the front page.
- Hero self-sabotage / blunders — dry and deadpan. Almost pitying. Minimal editorial commentary because none is needed. The facts speak for themselves, unfortunately for the hero.
- Minion accidentally saves the day — confused and slightly defensive. The editor isn't sure whether to be proud or embarrassed. Gerald probably had something to do with it.
- Sheer dumb luck — conspiratorial. "We're not saying it was divine intervention but we're not not saying it."
- Overwhelmed by numbers — clinical and corporate, written like an HR incident report.

Crumplethwaite's sidebar also shifts tone accordingly: effusive praise for the spectacular defeats, quiet devastated silence for the hero blunder ones (represented by a single italicized sentence, possibly just "I see."). Gerald wants a quote credit regardless of what happened.

Procedural generation pull order: the column first draws from events in the player's own dungeon before surfacing community defeats. A pit trap that finally claimed a victim should be DLM-worthy before the player sees anyone else's highlights.

Once community sourcing is live, featured players will likely screenshot and share — making this a built-in viral mechanic.

The Quarterly Review (Special Edition)

Released every three in-game months. Same publisher and voice as DLM, but longer-form and more retrospective. Arrives as a noticeably thicker issue.

Content includes: seasonal retrospectives, extended Crumplethwaite essays (more wrong, in greater depth), Gerald's quarterly employment report ("Still Looking"), dungeon-of-the-quarter awards, and deep investigative pieces like "What Really Happened at Dorkenfang's Dungeon: A Six-Month Investigation".

The fourth quarter issue is the annual edition, featuring year-in-review content, Dungeon Lord awards (categories include "Most Spectacular Failure"), and Crumplethwaite's predictions for the coming year — all of which are wrong.

Better Dungeons and Lairs (BDL)

A lifestyle and aspirational magazine, slightly expensive. Think Better Homes & Gardens if it were for evil overlords. Features dungeon design showcases, product reviews, and aspirational content. The Minion Manager appears here occasionally as a guest column when Gerald can afford the freelance fee — in BDL it's framed as self-help and productivity content, and Gerald pretends he has his life together.

Unlocks mid-game.

The Dungeonist

Premium serious journalism. The Economist, but underground.

The only publication in the ecosystem that is actually accurate and useful. Expensive, respected, and written by people who verify their sources. Unlocks late game.

The Dungeonist serves as the "graduate from tabloid to real news" progression reward. Players can compare DLM's rumors against The Dungeonist's facts, which is often illuminating and occasionally horrifying.

Unlock Requirements — The Dungeonist

The Dungeonist cannot be unlocked by money alone. This is an intentional design constraint to prevent players from grinding gold to skip mid-game progression.

Unlock requires both:

- A minimum dungeon reputation/rating threshold — the dungeon must actually be notable enough to warrant serious coverage
- A monetary requirement — serious journalism is expensive

The rating gate ensures players must build out their dungeon meaningfully before receiving the tools that make late-game play more strategic.

Ye Olde Dungeon Depot Catalog

The shopping interface. Arrives with DLM or separately. Treats dungeon supply procurement as a mail-order catalog experience. Product descriptions written in the same unreliable voice as DLM classifieds.

Publication Unlock Progression

Publications unlock in stages tied to dungeon development, creating a natural information ramp:

Early Game

DLM monthly issues only. Chaotic, unreliable, and funny. Players learn dungeon management through Crumplethwaite's bad advice and by reading between the lines of hero rumors. The Ye Olde Dungeon Depot Catalog is also available from the start.

Mid Game

DLM continues, Quarterly Reviews begin arriving, Better Dungeons and Lairs becomes available. More content variety. The Quarterly gives longer-term strategic perspective; BDL provides aspirational design goals. Quarterly Reviews get more ambitious as the dungeon grows.

Late Game

Everything, plus The Dungeonist. The ability to cross-reference DLM's tabloid rumors against The Dungeonist's accurate reporting is the mechanical payoff for building a reputable dungeon. Quarterly Reviews in this phase include investigative pieces and player dungeon performance retrospectives.

Recurring Characters

Crumplethwaite

Advice columnist. Has never successfully run a dungeon. Extremely confident. His sidebars appear across multiple column types and shift in tone to match the subject matter — effusive when things go well, quietly devastated by incompetence. Consider him the editorial conscience of DLM, except his conscience is also wrong.

Gerald

The Minion Manager columnist. A freelance foreman perpetually between jobs. His columns appear in whichever publication will pay his freelance fee that month, which explains the tonal inconsistency between issues. He files eyewitness accounts that contradict themselves, offers management advice from a position of being managed out of multiple dungeons, and always wants a quote credit.

Gerald's column across publications:

- In DLM — news and grievances framing
- In Better Dungeons and Lairs — lifestyle and self-help framing (he is pretending)
- In The Dungeonist — analytical deep dives into dungeon labor economics (he has a spreadsheet now)

Design Notes & Open Questions

- The "Hero Defeat of the Month" column name is a working title — DLM's house style would probably give it something more sensational. Options include: "The Ignominious Exit", "Fallen and Can't Get Up", "This Month's Most Spectacular Failure", "The Dungeon's Finest Hour" (told from the dungeon's POV), "In Memoriam... Just Kidding, They Respawned".
- The Quarterly Review's relationship to player dungeon performance data is worth exploring — it could give season-end rewards or rankings, making its arrival a mechanical event as well as a narrative one.
- Gerald's arc across a full playthrough is worth designing intentionally. Does he eventually land steady employment? Does the player have any agency over this?
- BDL's unlock cost vs. utility curve needs tuning — it should feel like a treat, not a necessity.